



Mailing lists

An e-mail discussion within a group of subscribers is the simplest and most familiar form of a virtual community. Anyone who can read and send e-mail can create a mailing list virtual community.

OneList, eGroups, ListBot, Cool List, and other free list-hosting sites let you search among the lists hosted on their site. Once you register and sign up for a particular group, you are on its mailing list. You can view messages on the group pages, read them in your inbox, post messages, reply collectively or individually, and more. On Yahoo! Groups (<http://groups.yahoo.com>) you can also have separate pages for members, polls, chat, etc. You can share photos and files, plan group events and network like never before.

Assuming you have Internet access, the only investment needed to start a mailing list or e-group is time. It's necessary to invest time—moderating a list, starting and maintaining discussion topics and so on, do require a modicum of skills and takes no little effort.

- ✓ Messages come to your e-mail box
- ✓ It's inexpensive—messages can be composed and read offline
- ✓ Reach: you can reach virtually anyone who's online

- ✗ Spammers can send messages to the list and gather e-mail addresses for advertising purposes
- ✗ Often a talkative group can quickly produce a daunting number of messages

Making online communities work for you

The type of community that's right for you depends on your needs. If you're just starting out and don't have a lot of traffic, you can launch an e-mail list or a guest book. If you have a high-traffic site, think message boards and chat rooms. Most hosting services don't charge too much, so it's easy to register with several of them and test them for a few weeks.

You'll quickly be able to assess the features of each service and decide the best fit for your needs. Community-building tools include e-mail, newsgroups, chat and message boards. Each has its advantages and disadvantages.

Internet access, access costs, computer and browser types, geographic and time zone issues all affect the means adopted by online communities to interact. People with high Internet connection costs might be best off using e-mail, e-mail topic subscription features, and newsletters.

If you're discussing sensitive or private issues, as might be the case in an

Online communities: vapourware?

Weblogs, journals and forum sites all tend to form the basis of these new communities, both because of the abundance of free, easy tools to generate them and the relative lack of effort required to maintain them. Thus, communities spread throughout the Internet, even while actual original content dwindles. The truth is that people make communities. However, the mere presence of a bulletin board with a few posts, or a chat room does not mean that people are forming anything worth the word 'community'.

"At **MouthShut**, we provide a common theme of consumers helping others



Douglas Rushkoff
AUTHOR OF *CYBERIA:
LIFE IN THE TRENCHES OF
HYPERSPACE*

I do believe we are in the midst of a transition—intimated by the Internet—towards a more collective thinking, where the individual psyche becomes a component of a larger group mind. This doesn't mean we stop existing as individuals, but it could mean we become more fully aware of every other living being, much in the way a coral reef's individual organisms respond to one another as if they were part of the same, single body

illness-support group, or a business workgroup, you may want to develop a private community. If you want to attract new and diverse members and ideas, you should choose a public community.

Using free services has worked well for most people. After all, for many individuals a free service is the only viable option. There are Yahoo! Clubs, Excite Clubs, Microsoft Communities, and Altavista Communities, to name a few. Each offers its services for free.

But more than anything, building your own community requires planning and vision. "First, understand your target audience and see what they need and what they lack. Make sure your community offering is strong enough to keep them coming back—not as passive observers but as active participants. Make sure that your moderators are in tune with the community you are building," says Web strategist, Lyndon Cerejo.

decide whether a product or service is good or bad. We are able to maintain 'stickiness' in our model by providing a complete user experience. The instant feedback among our members is what takes interactivity to a higher level and the attachment with the community only intensifies as one grows with it," says Faizal Farooqui, CEO of **Mouthshut.com**.

Cerejo says: "A loyal community of users creates the 'goodwill' that you see on a company's financial statement—it may not be hard cash, but it contributes to your value. That is from a purely non-commercial view."

It's a truth that applies to almost all online communities. Online community companies, from Talkcity to iVillage, are supported by volunteers who spend their free time maintaining the communities they love. The bottomline—it's people who make or break the communities.

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